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July 30, 2026

Dr. Hongjin Sun
Professor
Psychology, Neuroscience & Behavior
Faculty of Science

Re: Response to ethics review comments from the MREB Amendment, MREB#8215

Dear Dr. Sun:

Thank you and the reviewers for the feedback on our MREB amendment.

In response to your e-mail, dated July 28, 2026, we have revised the submission again to incorporate the new feedback. We provide a summary below.

- 1.3 Please select the status of your application. “When re-submitting your amendment, be sure to select the first item: ‘My revised amendment form in response to ethics review comments from the MREB Chair’. You will then be prompted to upload your Summary of Revisions document in 1.4 - the subsequent section”

This has been done. This document provides a summary of the revisions made in response to the ethics review comments on the amendments to MREB#8215.

- 3.7 For the change to the data collection methods, please address the following. “Please describe the platform you will use to collect survey data, and describe any collection, storage, and deletion procedures for this new kind of data you are collecting. Make sure this is reflected in the LOI and survey consent preamble as well.”

The response to 3.7 has been modified to address the reviewer’s concerns, with the following additional text: The survey is hosted on Microsoft forms through McMaster’s Microsoft 365. The survey is available here. There is no survey question to collect the participant’s name. However, the graduate students will know the set of people who were invited, and the principal investigator will know what raw data is associated with which project. Although the identity of the participants are not made explicit, it would be possible to deduce a small set of possibilities

from this available information. The LOI and survey consent preamble have been modified to make participants aware of this. The survey response data will be stored under Ziyang Fang's Microsoft 365 account. Only the two graduate students (Fang and Schankula) and the principal investigator (Smith) will have access to the data through their McMaster ID and authentication. At the conclusion of the retention period approved for this study, the researcher will delete the raw survey data by:

- 1. Deleting all responses from the Microsoft Form.*
- 2. Deleting the associated Excel workbook containing the responses from OneDrive.*
- 3. Removing the deleted items from the Microsoft 365 Recycle Bin and, if accessible, the Second-Stage Recycle Bin.*

Following these steps, the data will no longer be accessible to the research team through Microsoft 365. Residual copies may persist temporarily within McMaster University's managed Microsoft 365 backup and retention infrastructure in accordance with institutional policies, after which they are managed and disposed of by the institution and Microsoft according to their retention schedules. As for the interview transcript data, the raw survey data will be retained for 3 years after the study.

- 3.7.2 Upload any revised documents related to the data collection methods. “We think this document might be uploaded as a mistake - could you clarify? ”

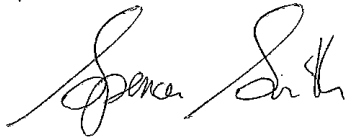
Yes, the document was incorrectly uploaded. The document should have shown the survey questions, with the consent preamble. A new version will be uploaded, which includes the changes needed to address the other concerns. The survey consent preamble is very similar to the oral script used before the interviews start. The consent preamble is also uploaded as a separate document (without the survey questions) that has track changes enabled.

- 6.6.1 Upload any new or revised documents related to the changes above. “LETTER OF INFORMATION / CONSENT Confidentiality section - Please describe the platform being used to collect the survey, and reflect the survey data storage details Participation and Withdrawal: - Consider if you are collecting survey data that is identifiable enough for you to withdraw it if a participant chooses withdrawal after submitting (if there are nuances to this, be sure to also reflect it in the consent script/preamble that you are using for survey participants, e.g. bullet #2 under voluntary participation will need to be revised).”

Most of the documents have been modified, even if it is just to update the deadline for withdrawing data, which is changing from August 8th to 30th, in recognition of the delay in getting the survey up and running. The platform (Microsoft Forms) has been added and the steps for withdrawal from the survey have been outlined.

In the cases where a new version of a document is available, the previous version is deleted.

Best regards,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Spencer Smith". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Spencer" and last name "Smith" clearly distinguishable.

Spencer Smith